This is My Audition Monologue

By Sara Zarr

RACHEL: **(Pg 319-328)** I wrote it. *(beat)* I know we're supposed to pick something from a *(airquotes)* quote-unquote known work by Shakespeare or Chekhov, or one of those monologues in the drama room, but I looked at them and honestly there's nothing that shows my range or says anything about who I am that will be memorable. And that's what I need: to be memorable. Because, and I'm not trying to embarrass you, but you've had trouble remembering my name since I started auditioning freshman year. So obviously I need to take a new approach.

Look at the audition form and look at my face: **Rachel Banks.** Not Rochelle, not Ruthie, not Melissa -- I really don't understand where you got that last one, but you have called me Melissa at least three times. So, my goal here is to be memorable. [So] . . .

INTRODUCTION

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RACHEL: You can start timing me . . . now. *(deep breath)* Scotty King got electrocuted while running the light board. It sounds like a joke, I know, but I'm saying that he ***got electrocuted.*** While ***running the light board.*** I'm saying that he died, during the second act of *Miracle Worker* when Julie-Ann Leskowitz had gotten so good at playing blind, deaf, and dumb that she didn't stop her scene, even though the lights flashed and everyone heard the sizzling noise from up in the booth and Annie Sullivan stopped and said, "Oh my God, Scotty," because she knew about the leak in the auditorium roof and Scotty's belief that bare feet were good luck and we were having one of those late spring storms and there were puddles and drips everywhere, and she put it all together faster than any of us. And we stopped the show and people filed out, a lot of them not realizing what had happened

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and asking if they'd get a refund. Seriously, who asks for a refund for a seven-dollar high school play? I'm sorry, I'm still making it sound like a joke. You don't know this about me, since you've never taken the time to know anything about me, but I use humor that way. It relieves the tension. Unless someone is actually dead, like Scotty, in which case it just ends up sounding sick and insensitive.

You know all this, of course, you were there. What you may not realize is that it was supposed to be me. *(beat)* Now it doesn't sound like a joke. Now it sounds like I'm trying to get attention or turn the focus away from Scotty's tragedy on to me.

If it had been me, would anyone have noticed? One, I'm obviously not memorable. I've never gotten a part. I audition every single time, and this is the mistake I've made. On the part of the audition form where it says: ***In the event you are not cast in the play, would you be willing to work behind the scenes on this production?*** I always put a checkmark in the YES box. Every time I see that question I think to myself:

Rachel, don't check yes. DO NOT CHECK IT!

What happens is the part of me that would rather mop up Julie-Ann's sweat or de-crust the greenroom furniture than not have anything to do with the play panics and I check YES. Yes, use me. Yes, abuse me. Yes, make me post call times in my own blood, I will do it. I will do anything, ***anything*** to be in the general vicinity of this auditorium every single day, including weekends.

Hence the trying-something-new-and-memorable ploy of writing my own audition, hoping it will help me relax (and it kind of is, now that I think about it). When I do the lines in my room and no one is watching, I'm so, so good and that isn't bragging. When I practice in my room, I'm Sarah Bernhardt, I'm Julie Harris, I'm Dame Judi Dench, for real. Then I get in front of you and anyone else who might be in the room, I am so bad. So truly bad. Even I know how bad I am.

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When there are lines, I say the wrong ones at the wrong time, in a total monotone, and I don't know what to do with my hands, and one time I drooled. I was staring at the page with my mouth sort of agape I guess, because I lost my place, and this string of drool, sparkling in the stage lights, oozed right out.

This is why I check the YES box [and] how I ended up running lights. When I hand-picked Scotty to be my lighting assistant, my intent was not to kill. Originally, he wasn't supposed to be running the board at all. Originally, he would have been my errand boy, my cue keeper, my clipboard peon. [But] I didn't want to do lights. What I ***wanted*** was to be onstage; but since that didn't happen, I hoped that while Scotty took care of things, I could spend a little more time with the actors and soak up some of their actory personalities.

Ever since I checked my first YES box, I've been stuck in this limbo between techie and performer. Unlike the techies, I do not own seventeen different black T-shirts. I do not spend my weekends scouring yard sales for the perfect Agatha Christie ashtray or Oscar Wilde table lamp. At the same time, I know I'll never be one of those sparkling, chosen, beautiful oddballs that have "The Second I Turn Eighteen I'm Moving to New York" written all over them. I think too hard before I talk. I haven't considered how I look from all angles. I can't break into songs from *Spring Awakening* at the drop of a wool stocking. I have never dared to wear an item of clothing that strays from my jeans-and-cardigan comfort zone.

Which is why I put Scotty on the board and tried to spend a little more time with the Chosen. I thought if I want to be an actor so bad maybe I could at least try to act like an actor acts. Fake it 'til you make it. Most people do not look at Rachel Banks and think: Drama Nerd. Most people do not look at Rachel Banks and remember that Rachel Banks is her name.

The funny thing is I thought drama would be a place where being not like the others was okay, but it turns out you have to be not like the others in a way that is exactly like the others who are not like the others.

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This is why I'm not doing that stupid piece from *Butterflies Are Free* for my audition and instead am trying to tell you who I am because let me assure you, I will never be one of them. Not in the way you expect me to. For one thing I don't have that thing, that instinct that tells me about vintage tube tops and asymmetrical hair. But I know that doesn't matter, that someday some director, some boy, some anybody, will like me plain and in my cardigan and not be blind to me just because I'm not aggressively DIFFERENT.

If I do this, if I leave this school and go on to study theater or go on auditions out in the real world and start getting parts, it's not going to be because I am oh so delightfully quirky and wear unmatched shoes and tiaras around town. It's going to be because I love it, and because I have paid my dues and been willing to check that YES box every time if only so that I can watch and learn and get out of here and finally become the real Rachel who will then go out and claim the parts that are out there waiting for me. I have what the rest of these girls do not. Passion.

Some might say I shirked my responsibilities by putting Scotty on the board at the last minute. But I figured since you don't remember my name you wouldn't really care if it were me or Scotty or the Queen of Sheba actually running the board, while the other one of us stayed backstage on the headset.

I know it wasn't my fault. I know I don't have any real responsibility for Scotty's death, that it was a freak accident. And I also can't help but think Scotty's death was a sign, someone up there telling me:

- Stop checking the YES box.
- Stop being willing to stay behind the scenes when what you want is to be *in* the scenes.

I've only got one more year and I've proved my dedication. The fact that I'm even here auditioning after what happened proves that I know the basic truth of plays and life: The show must go on. Even when it's hard to watch the show going on without you.

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I'll take any part, I will; and if it's Onlooker #8, I will be the best Onlooker #8 this town has ever seen. But if you can't find a part for me, I'm going to walk away. I'm not going to hang around in the shadows anymore. This time you'll remember my name.

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